

GLOBAL HIT *Squid Game*'s lead actors LeeJung-jae and Lee Byung-hun (right)

OTT ▲

END GAME

Hit Korean drama Squid Game, whose final season drops later this month, has resonated with global—and Indian—audiences

All good things come to an end, and so it is with Netflix's hit Korean drama, *Squid Game*. The most-watched international original of all time in India, the series concludes with the finale streaming from June 27. Such has been the show's cultural impact that the hooded pink jumpsuits and green tracksuits are a common sight at cosplay parties. Lead actor Lee Jung-jae, who essays player #456, the emotional heart of the show, never imagined *Squid Game* would strike a chord as far as India. "To be able to speak to people from all over the world is one of the biggest joys to come out of it," he said in an exclusive interview with INDIA TODAY.

Part of *Squid Game*'s universal appeal can be attributed to it shining a light on the economic disparity that compels the have-nots to take extreme measures to survive. For Lee Byung-hun, who plays the man behind the mask running the disturbing game, it's what makes the "global phenomenon" status of the show feel bittersweet. "We are happy [about the show's success], but the fact that global audiences loved it also means that they resonated with the saddening themes of losing hope and humanity... and being divided and taking sides." Production director Hwang Dong-hyuk says he hopes the show inspires viewers. "What I want to tell through season three is that we need to look into our own inner worlds and try to find some empathy and a conscience."

With the finale poised to break viewing records, Dong-hyuk admits he is ready to "say goodbye to the show" he conceived back in 2009 when he had hit rock bottom. "I projected so much of myself into the show," he says, "but it is time to leave it behind, prepare for the next step." ■

—Suhani Singh

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